you and me (together at the end of the world)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31322423.

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Not Rated

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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by Histmex, tearbendingpro

Summary

"What if something happens to us out there? You know the stories Weaver tells us about the outside." Catra mumbled before a sob escaped her throat.
"Nothing bad is going to happen to us."
"How do you know?" Catra sat up and the mismatched eyes met the blue ones who gave her so much comfort.
"Because you'll look out for me as I look out for you. Nothing really bad is going to happen to us if we stick together."
Adora wiped the stranded tears off Catra's cheeks when she sat up as well.
"You promise?"
"I promise."

There was a time before guns, swords, claws, trains, and crimes where all Catra and Adora had was each other.

Notes

This little short piece of work is a prequel to White Lies, though you don't have to read it before it. (If you do it'll hurt more ;)) Since at the moment White Lies is ongoing, this fanfic will be slow in the uploading to avoid accidental spoilers. I started writing it to keep myself centered when writing the Catradora flashbacks of the main fanfic and I don't see any reason why not post it as well.

Consider this one of my Catradora anniversary gifts to you guys :D

Promise

There's something about being abandoned that sticks to your skin, almost like a disease that you can't seem to get rid of. It never leaves you, not even when you find yourself laughing with the only person you seem to care about while playing a game of tag. Even though you're close to finally catching up to them, feeling the thrill of the whole thing shake your bones with excitement, there's always a voice in the back of your head and it won't leave you alone. *She'll leave you too* , it whispered but it was also so loud at the same time. Not even the quick footsteps that sounded beneath a ten-year-old Catalina as she made her way down the hall to chase after Adora seemed to quiet down the voice. She sprinted past the kitchen where the calendar sat on the furthest wall with today's date.

October 28th, 2135

It was Catalina's birthday, though the smaller girl would never celebrate it big. No, those parties and cake were preserved for January 19th only and the pang of jealousy was always heavy in some part of her mind. Adora got everything she wanted, but Catalina wasn't going to let her win this game of catch. Not that she ever did. Though Adora was bigger than the other kids in the orphanage, Catalina always had speed and agility on her side, making it really difficult for Adora to keep up with her when they played in the backyard. Today was a rainy day, however, so they weren't allowed outside to play. Catalina wanted to forget about their small tradition and simply sit on the TV to watch her favorite movie, but Adora had insisted on just forgetting about the rules and having fun. Since then, they've been at it on and off during the whole day until the sunset. The blonde always seemed eager to celebrate the day Catalina arrived in the world because that was the day her best friend was assigned to her. *"You're an idiot." She whispered at Adora under the covers after she had confessed that during the night.*

When the smaller girl arrived at the orphanage five years ago, Adora was already there but she never got close to her. The little girl, who barely spoke English, was too busy trying to understand why her mother had left her here that cloudy afternoon. Whenever it was cloudy, she would remember the day that Ellen Weaver took her hand and shoved her through the front door after a quick wave from her mom. It hurt. Lord knows it did. Though Catalina didn't understand the circumstances, she did know that she was beyond angry. Her mother was the first-ever person to promise to never leave her, and then she did that exact thing. "You… betrayed me", Catalina would often whisper within herself whenever her mother's memory came into mind.

Pushing people away to avoid this happening again wasn't a philosophy that a small four-year-old had to deal with. Yet, whenever any kid from the orphanage tried to get close to her, Catalina would become violent towards them so they would leave her alone; especially when they came with *remarks* about her heritage. This behavior never went unpunished: Weaver always found out and took her to her room while the other kids stayed outside playing. Catalina would then return and sit on her usual corner in the living room, trying not to whimper from the pain on her sides and behind; rubbing the invisible bruises on her wrists. It was hell; Catalina hated everything about this place. Or so she did, until one day she opened her eyes -which she had closed to avoid the tears spill- to meet greyish blue ones while sitting in the exact same spot. The blonde girl sat across from her and when they locked eyes she gasped.

"Your eyes are so cool." The little girl whispered in awe and Catalina pulled her knees to her chest, suddenly feeling embarrassed about her mismatched eyes. Amber and blue. She didn't know what the girl meant and she thought of the worse, hiding her eyes with a glance to the side. The small blonde should've noticed because she frowned. "I like them." Now Catalina understood.

"Thank you." She whispered, resting her chin on her knees. The little girl smiled.

“What’s your name? I’m Adora!”

“Catalina.” The small girl didn’t know why Adora was the exception to her small rule, but she wasn’t going to question it. After all, to Catalina, Adora was the only girl in the house who didn’t make fun of her heritage or bothered her personal space. That made Catalina comfortable enough to smile a little at Adora’s confused gaze.

“Cat..” The blonde trailed off and concentrated. After a few attempts and butchering the name, Catalina giggled.

“Call me Cata.” Catalina offered the simple nickname and Adora grinned, exposing a missing front tooth.

“Catra!” Her smile faded, even though Catalina was laughing at her mistake. “I said that wrong.” She whined.

“I like it.” She did; it was a unique nickname.

Since that day, Adora and Catra were inseparable and the latter noticed how Weaver seemed to hate it. She couldn’t care less, though, Catra was happy with her new friend. They would eat together, play together, and share Adora’s bed often so they wouldn’t fall asleep; staying up all night whispering about whatever entertained them during the day. For Catra, loving Adora came as easy and she was sure Adora loved her too to some extent. Hell, the blonde would even beat up the kids who would make fun of Catra for being Hispanic and calmed down the feeling of betrayal that always bubbled from the pit of Catra’s stomach.

“Her loss if she left. You’re the best person ever!” Adora would say to try and comfort the crying mess in her arms in the middle of the night.

When Catra rounded the corner at full speed, she wasn’t met with the empty hallway as she had expected. The little girl slid into a

halt when she saw Shadow Weaver -the nickname they had come up with- standing with an angry look on her face, Adora standing next to her looking afraid. A hand forcefully grabbed Catra's shoulder and Weaver leaned down with a glare.

"Insolent child. What have I said about running inside of the house?" Catra looked at her horrified and stuttered on her words. "Answer me!"

"It was my fault!" Adora pushed Catra away and got in between them, as she had done many times before. For some reason, her intervening upset Catra. "I wanted to play tag!"

"Adora…" The older woman brushed a strand of her ponytail that had gotten loose. "It's not your fault. However, you should do a better job at keeping *her* in check. The times that you don't, I will." Weaver straightened up and took Catra's arm, dragging her against her will towards the room. "Now run along, get dinner and go to bed."

The door closed behind them, Catra losing Adora's gaze behind it.

Catra didn't leave the room for what felt like forever.

When she made her way down the hall to their room with her cheeks stained with tears and her body sore, everyone had gone to bed. No dinner for her this time, she guessed. Not a surprise. The little girl made her way quietly up to her bed in the top bunk instead of Adora's, and hid under the covers, sobbing quietly. She hated Weaver, she hated her mom, she hated this place, she h-

"Catra…" Adora called out softly and was met with a whimper from Catra. The latter felt the bed dip next to her and the warmth of Adora curling up to her. "I'm sorr-"

"Why do you always have to play hero?" Though her English had gotten way better during these past few years, Catra's accent clung heavily to her words. "We both know she won't actually hurt you."

"Catra, I'll always try to protect you. Even if it turns out useless." She swore she could feel Adora's face contour. "Seeing you hurting… it hurts me too." Catra was about to reply when the dam broke again and she started sobbing. Adora held to her for dear life and Catra noticed she was crying as well.

"I hate her, Adora. I want to leave and never come back." Catra whimpered and Adora stayed silent for a few moments.

"Let's leave then." Adora shifted her position and laid Catra's head on her shoulder. "Let's run away and find somewhere else to live."

"Where would we even go?" Catra raised her eyebrow.

"I… I don't know but…" The blonde took a deep breath. "We'll figure it out. We can't hide forever, sometimes we have to run."

"What if something happens to us out there? You know the stories Weaver tells us about the outside." Catra mumbled before a sob escaped her throat.

"Nothing bad is going to happen to us."

"How do you know?" Catra sat up and the mismatched eyes met the blue ones who gave her so much comfort.

"Because you'll look out for me as I look out for you. Nothing really bad is going to happen to us if we stick together." Adora wiped the stranded tears off Catra's cheeks when she sat up as well.

"You promise?"

"I promise."

Catra and Adora stayed silent, staring at each other for a few beats. Adora tore their staring contest when she pulled back and leaned down towards the bedside table. Another tradition of theirs was that Adora always tried to sneak Catra a dessert since Shadow Weaver never let the latter have any. In return, for

Adora's birthday, Catra would always give something handmade to Adora. The blonde girl straightened up and gave Catra a small cupcake with a smile, one that made Catra's lips curl up slightly.

"Happy birthday, Catra." She whispered and gave away the cupcake. The smaller girl took it and split it in half so they could share, then fell back into thought as they ate.

She thought for a moment of whenever Weaver would tell them about the robots that lived on the outside and how they forced children to become like them. Catra felt her lips curl down in a frown when she realized that she preferred that, rather than succumb to Shadow Weaver's abuse any longer. Without hesitation, Catra jumped down from her bed after finishing the dessert and looked through the closet for their backpacks. When she showed them to her, Adora smiled and joined her, helping the younger girl pack some clothes and shoes.

Soon enough, they were making their way around the house towards the front door. Catra retrieved the key from the place Shadow Weaver always kept it and, with Adora's help, opened the door towards their freedom. It was easy, almost too easy, and Catra wished she hadn't thought it because yelling from the kitchen made them almost freeze.

"WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'RE DOING?!" Weaver's voice rang out and Catra widened her eyes in fear.

"Run!" Adora yelled and they were both sprinting down the street as fast as they could from the yelling woman on the porch. The darkness of the night soon surrounded them but they didn't stop running until they physically gave out.

Once again, the quick and now heavy footsteps underneath and behind Catra filled her senses but never quieted down the voices. *She'll leave you soon enough,* it snarled and Catra felt herself wincing. The difference now was that when she looked sideways, Adora was there, running with her to Lord-knows-where in the night; to wherever their feet took them. It calmed down the sense

of nervousness that had piled up on Catra's chest and she found herself grinning as the wind hit her face and realization struck.

Adora would always be there for her and Catra would hold their promise against her heart as hard as she could.

Hopefull Constellations

Chapter by Histmex

Chapter Summary

Stars bring comfort

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

April 21, 2137

(2 years later)

The adrenaline was always a bonus, the gig was an easy one for them: steal from unsuspecting tourists or locals and sell them for profit at different thrift stores or in pawnshops. No one questioned them, they got their payments in cash, and they made enough to sustain themselves for now. However, the hardest part of the job was always getting those items into their pockets. It was like playing Russian roulette, you always had to expect the bullet; or, in this case, you always have to expect the victim to notice that they were missing something and just run. They tried to leave this one alone, they really did, but the gold watch seemed too intriguing for them to just ignore. The process was quite simple: Catra would spill the drink she was now holding all over him and Adora would distract him with an apology so Catra could slip out the watch from his wrist. They used this same trick almost constantly for the last two years, but somehow this one turned out sloppy.

Catra just knew he would notice. In fact, she was so certain that he would, that she started counting as soon as Adora and her starting walking away. 3...2...1...

“Someone stop them! They have my watch!”

Catra smirked. Just in time. The funny thing, though? Not only his watch but a wallet, multiple rings, a necklace, loose money, and an expensive bracelet full of charms around it.

Catra laughed as they made their way through the crowd with the new watch on her wrist and the stolen items in both hers and Adora’s pockets. They ran past the blues through the main plaza of Covington, where the old clock tower was still standing; new buildings all around it. Though they tried to keep the original architecture around the town, you could see skyscrapers, the monorail tracks, and the neon lights and signs that adorned the night. Catra took a deep breath and sprinted past the statue down to the buildings on the west side of the town with Adora hot on her trail, losing the man through the multitude of people that were around the area in celebration. She looked back and saw Adora grinning at her, encouraging Catra to pick up her speed.

No hesitation was taken into consideration when she sprinted down the narrowed alley and jumped, kicking herself in between the buildings until she reached the balcony in one of them and pulled herself up, helping Adora up with the help of her momentum after she made it. They have taken this route before, every time they made their way to the small town and stole from the tourists. Not having anyone on their trail, Catra relaxed and guided Adora from balcony to balcony until she reached the street that led to their destination. She jumped down from the roof she was standing on, down to a piece of zync that was used as a balcony roof, then down to the floor with a hmph. Adora landed next to her and, after giving her a smile, Catra whistled a soft tune as they walked across the street to the small monorail station, the one they always used to get from wherever they were to Downtown Atlanta and vice versa.

Being small had its advantages, and Catra learned these past two years to use them to the fullest. Sneaking around crowds and slipping her hands into pockets unnoticed was just one of the many skills she taught herself. At first, it was quite hard to run

away from her victims, but now? She was unstoppable and she had these random kids in the park she found one day to thank. Apparently, parkour was a thing, and Catra learned a few things from them before they moved to Downtown Atlanta a few months after escaping. It was getting risky, staying at the same place where Weaver could appear randomly and snatch them back to the orphanage, a severe punishment waiting for Catra as soon as they got behind her locked door.

Catra shivered at the thought. Never again. Weaver would be the first and last person that would lay hands on her that way.

Then she learned from this guy, Kowl, the basics to lock picking and now it was all about being at the right place and time, and taught them all to Adora. Abandoned storage units, houses, and garages became her primary focus; snatching away items that she could use for a quick buck. One day they got lucky and found old collectibles in one of the houses. Something called Pops? Didn't matter to her, they got a healthy sum of money and bought a pullout couch. Now that had been a very much appreciated investment, considering that they would sleep on the ground before it. Yet, what really caught Catra's eye one day was the thing that became her frustrated dream for the next couple of years. Abandoned in an old garage, sitting in poor conditions, was an old 1980's 300zx, and Lord was it beautiful. Catra would sometimes even sneak into that house with Adora and sit on it, dreaming of the day she'll manage to have one. Of course, that -in her mind- would never happen. Sure, she gained quite a bit with her stealing schemes but not enough to stick out from the rest of the street kids.

Catra bumped into an old couple quite harshly and quickly excused herself and apologized, dusting off the man's expensive white suit. The couple simply smiled and waved her and Adora off, walking away and not noticing Catra's newly acquired tickets for the monorail. She handed the officer the tickets and they snuck into the transport, taking the furthest seat by the window. Watching the considerable small town disappear and taller buildings quickly approach them, she couldn't stop the thought

that made its way to her mind. Truth was, *I'll never have it.* No, not with this minimal work. She wanted *more.*

"Did you really have to steal from the old couple?" Adora whispered and Catra looked over to find her with her arms crossed and a frown on her face. Guilt, Catra could recognize that expression on Adora's face in a second. It was simply so common. That seemed to be the main difference between the both of them. Truth was, Catra wouldn't have thought twice about that and could care less as long as it got them home.

"Do you have a better idea?" She mumbled and Adora furrowed her eyebrows.

"We could've bought them. We have the money." They locked eyes and Catra quickly looked away, shaking her head slightly. She couldn't handle how Adora's eyes made her feel when they were so full of negative feelings.

"And risk questions? What if they figure out the truth? I don't want to risk it." Catra grumbled while looking at the city pass by through the window and Adora hummed, staying silent the rest of the way.

When they arrived at their destination, they quickly got off and out of the station, making their way down to her next stop. Catra looked down at the golden watch. *7:15p.m.* The pawnshop they frequented on Thursdays, though it was late, was surely open still and they quickly made their way towards the place. Catra couldn't help but let her mind wander during their small walk, especially when Adora seemed to relax the atmosphere enough for her to do so. Ah yes, that's exactly what Catra wanted to think about: Adora. It seemed that during the past few months that was all that clouded her mind, she just didn't understand why. That applied to a lot of things. She didn't understand why she suddenly started feeling slightly nervous around the blonde, especially when her gaze settled on her and those blue eyes became intense. That was one thing in particular that Catra loved about Adora because Catra *did* love Adora, but suddenly the

classification of that love blurred and Catra didn't know what Adora felt.

I doubt she feels that way towards me , and Catra knew she felt *something* . It seemed that Adora speaking to other people and the attempt at a friendship was made, Catra would get territorial and plain jealous. The cause was a list of many things, the one above the list being the promise. Catra knew that, if necessary, she would get herself killed and would hurt whoever hurt *her.* Alas, that wasn't normal and she blamed it on a sense of loyalty towards Adora; on wanting to repay the many times she took care of her during their time in the orphanage. She just didn't want Adora to get hurt by a random person. This is why Catra couldn't even begin to imagine Adora having that sense of responsibility towards her. Sure Adora would keep their promise, but would she for the same reasons? Hell, at times Catra even thought that Adora regretted coming with her, especially when Catra would lash out and be mean to her because she didn't know how to handle these odd feelings.

Catra was snapped out of her thoughts by Adora's sudden hand movement. She watched the blonde snap a daisy from the sidewalk planter as they walked by it. Adora smelled it and handed it to Catra with the same sheepish grin the brunette seemed to be giving the blonde quite often. In fact, she was gifting Adora that same grin as she took the flower and put it on the collar her jacket. Maybe she did feel the same way? Only one could hope. Adora reached over and poked one of Catra's unusual sharpened fangs and she could only roll her eyes, cherishing the sound of Adora's giggling.

"Are you ever going to stop doing that?" The blonde shook her head, her full grin dropping into a warm smile.

"Maybe when we separate, which will never happen." Adora took Catra's hand and they both hurried down the street when they saw a familiar sign. "It's always going to be you and me, together at the end of the world." Catra smiled. Hope. Catra kept feeling hope.

“You promise?” Catra looked over at Adora with hopeful eyes.

“I promise.” The blonde stare back with genuine determination in her eyes, before opening the door to the establishment; *The Black Garnet* shone in crimson red neon over the front door.

It was a relatively small pawn shop in the shady area of town. There were racks on the left side of it, a few glass displays filled with random things adorned the center of it, and at the very end stood a long one with jewelry and a cash register on top of it. Behind that and the woman who was reading something with a bored expression on her tablet was a row of guitars in display and sound systems on the shelves under them. One of them always caught Catra’s attention, since the girl seemed to have a love for everything vintage. An ebony Gibson Les Paul had Catra gawking over it since she first got set foot on the store looking for a place to sell her acquired items. She often mentioned it to Adora, who always seemed to study the guitar with her.

“Was beginning to think you two wouldn’t show up.” The woman grumbled and Catra rolled her eyes.

“Almost didn’t so I didn’t have to look at your dumb face.” Catra mumbled.

“What did you say?!”

“That we’re sorry we got here late.” Adora let out a nervous laugh and watched as Octavia and Catra glared at each other intensively. It’s as if Catra had a death wish, considering how big Octavia was in comparison. Without another word, Catra threw the jewelry she had stolen today at the table and started walking around the store as Adora finished the transaction. She hated Octavia’s guts, but she was one of the few that exchanged for cash constantly with no questions asked. The world now worked through cyber transactions you see, almost like an easier PayPal, and Catra and Adora certainly didn’t have that. She also didn’t ask questions about where they acquired the stuff, but that wasn’t free at all. Octavia would take 20% of the gain for her silence.

Catra walked around the store looking around while Octavia and Adora did the math together at the counter. She hated it, most of it except for the adrenaline of committing the crimes. No, Catra actually hated the fact that they were suddenly working for Octavia and were beginning to steal exclusively for her. She didn't want to be an employee, Catra wanted to be the one to call the shots, and she would often dream about it too; about being at the top and touching the sky with Adora by her side. The brunette knew that they weren't going to get there by just stealing jewelry and selling it for far too low to pawn shops, though the gig that Adora had come up with was indeed efficient. They needed to do more, to be more, and, quite frankly, Catra knew that Adora would hate herself more if they did. In fact, because of this, Catra often thought of just leaving and starting over so that Adora could as well.

A shimmer caught her eyes and they widened slightly. Her eyes landed on the most beautiful brass knuckles she had ever seen, with spikes and made in almost a paw shape. She quickly tried to weight the cons and pros on her mind but she couldn't help herself. When Adora called her name to tell her that they were leaving, they were already in her back pocket and they weighed heavily on it throughout the whole walk to the place they called home. If Octavia found out they would surely be dead, but Catra had one excuse in mind. *You just can't progress without risks* . That moved her during this time on the streets.

When a certain gate came into view, Catra sped up and climbed it with ease. She straddled it and held a hand out for Adora to take and helped her up, both jumping to the other side together. They worked together in sync. Catra made her way to the door to open it and gave Adora the flashlight they kept next to it. The blonde quickly made her way to the back of the building and, as she turned on the generator, Catra turned on the lights of their so-called home. It wasn't much but it was something, it was just a once empty space that now had a foldable table, a mini-fridge for water, some chairs, a nightstand where Catra kept their gadgets -tablets and a laptop they had kept for their entertainment-, a small couch, a dresser where they kept all their belongings, a

portable closet next to it and finally the pull-out couch in the middle of it all ready to be slept in. On the far right of the room stood a surprisingly functional bathroom and they had bought a portable shower to keep inside of it. Lastly, on the remaining open space, they had a small area they used for sparring with makeshift staffs and practiced hand-to-hand combat, all courtesy of the videos they would download during the day with public Wi-Fi and watch during the night. It wasn't much but neither of them complained. They built it together, lived it together and it was better than sleeping behind dumpsters as they did before Adora found this place. They had cleaned it up and made it their own, and that's all that matters.

Catra was taking out two bottles of water from the fridge and frowning at the fact that they were running out when Adora called out for her. She straightened up and looked over at the blonde, who was walking over to her.

"We are running out of diesel. I don't know if it'll be enough to last the night." She took the bottle of water from Catra with a frown and the brunette gave her a small smile.

"Don't worry, I'll go buy some and more water in the morning." Adora stopped opening the bottle with a sigh.

"With what little Octavia paid us today we won't be able to without taking money from the savings jar." Right, the one they had with the hopes of finding an actual apartment.

"Don't worry about that." Catra waved her off and started drinking her water. When Adora stayed silent she spoke again. "I got something that will get us some cash at the local weapon store." She pulled out the brass knuckles and swore that Adora's face paled. "I was gonna keep them for mysel-"

"You stole those from Octavia?!" Adora yelled and Catra simply nodded, slipping them on and flexing her hands. "Catra…"

"She won't find out, don't worry about it."

“And if she does?”

“I’ll beat her up with them.” Catra beamed and Adora bit her lip to keep herself from smiling. It was impossible to stay mad at Catra at times. “Want me to show you?” Catra put her fists up and punched the air a few times.

“No, I’ll pass.” Adora finally drank from the bottle. “Those things are dangerous.”

“I won’t hit you.” Catra rolled her eyes. “Come on… please?” She pouted and Adora chuckled.

Without saying anything else, Adora simply got into a defensive stance, making Catra grin at her. Of course, it was a stupid idea, but that doesn’t matter when the main focus is fun. Safety is thrown at the window, but Catra threw it across a park with all her strength. She didn’t hold back and started hitting left and right. It was exhilarating and Adora was perfect for this, considering that she could block her with ease. To some extent, it frustrated Catra, which was good since she could release all the pent-up energy and current frustrations. However, in the midst of it all, Catra forgot all about the brass knuckles; and what was meant to be a gentle punch to Adora’s jaw turned into an agonizing blow that drew blood instantly.

“FUCK!” Adora yelped as she landed on the floor harshly and covered her bleeding jaw with her hand. She groaned in pain and closed her eyes tightly, tears starting to well upon them.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck.” Catra quickly rushed to Adora’s side, gently holding her wrist. “Let me see…” She mumbled and Adora looked at her, tears streaming rapidly down her face and sobs escaping her mouth. Reluctantly, she let Catra pry her hand off her face and saw how the brunette winced. There were three gashes running down her jaw from what she could see, ones that would surely scar. *I hurt her.* That was the only thing in her mind as she stood up and looked for the medkit.

Cleaning Adora hurt, no more than the three gashes on her face hurt her for sure, but it was a different kind of pain. Catra felt disgusting. Though Adora would reassure her whenever she saw the apologetic mismatched eyes, Catra couldn't even apologize with her own words. No, she was supposed to keep her end of the promise and look after Adora, and all she did was leave three marks that Adora would have to carry forever. The worse part? Catra felt like Weaver, and she couldn't stop listening to the things that she would say. *You're no good for her, you'll just hurt her* , was the mildest of all of them; it was driving her insane, just as Adora's gentleness did. Reassurance fell to deaf ears, Catra had imprinted herself on the fact that she didn't deserve forgiveness. Hell, she was even convinced that Adora hated her for a split second.

Then Adora asked her to stay and sleep with her on the pull-out couch, despite Catra hurting her an hour prior and attempting to sleep somewhere else for the night. "Brings me comfort." The blonde mumbled, drowsy on some pain killers Catra had gone out to get her. Soon enough she was laying on her back with Adora clinging to her with her head on Catra's chest.

Suddenly Catra realized that it wasn't only forgiveness, she just didn't deserve Adora at all.

Which is why Catra left Adora's side when she woke up from a nightmare and checked if Adora was fast asleep. After drying up the cold sweat and grounding herself slightly, she got her tablet and climbed up to the roof of the warehouse. She did this every time her thoughts got too loud, when Weaver's voice wouldn't quiet down and when emotions overwhelmed her. The light pollution of the city made seeing stars almost impossible, but Catra didn't let this stop her. She would open constellation maps on her tablet, position herself and stare up at the sky, imagining the stars forming the shapes on it. Her favorite constellation to imagine was Pegasus, simply because it reminded her of Adora's obsession with horses. *Adora* . It was now in this peace and quiet that Catra could truly think, and thoughts from earlier resurfaced. They were just too honest and Catra found herself thinking of the

worse: that Adora would actually be better off without her, that she'd be happier. That suddenly became Catra's biggest worry, drowning in it so much that she didn't hear the footprints against the zinc.

"You okay?" Adora asked with her voice full of sleep and sat down next to Catra. Her eyes trailed along Adora's face and settled on the blood-covered bandage on her face. The latter wanted to say so much, to yell that she wasn't okay, that Weaver still haunted her thoughts and dreams, that she had hurt Adora and absolutely hated herself for it and that she didn't deserve forgiveness. She considered asking her if she would actually be happier without her if maybe they should part ways. Then Adora simply tucked a strand of Catra's wild hair behind her ear and the brunette sighed in comfort, looking down at her tablet.

"Did you know that there are abandoned observatories across the states? The areas were never used so they have a clear view of the sky." Adora was surely disappointed at the change of topic but didn't seem to show it. "I always wanted to go see them." They stayed silent for a few moments, then Adora decided to speak up.

"Why don't we go then?" She asked and Catra finally looked at her with slight disbelief.

"After what I did to you I wouldn't want to even go around the corner with me." Catra mumbled and Adora simply smiled, nudging her with her shoulder softly.

"It was an accident, Catra. We look out for each other, you wouldn't do it on purpose." That was true, Catra knew it all too well and it made her smile slightly. Then she frowned.

"We don't have any money."

"We'll use the money-saving jar, Catra. I don't want to stay here forever and I'm sure you don't either." Catra smiled again and looked up at the sky.

Hope. Catra felt hope.

"Are you sure?" She looked from the dark sky over to Adora's clear ones and the blonde nodded.

"Catra, there's nowhere in the world I'd want to go without you. Remember what I said earlier?"

"That it's always going to be you and me, together at the end of the world?" Adora smiled.

"Exactly, and if you want to travel the country...why shouldn't we? Nothing ties us here, we have everything we need in each other." Catra smiled this time. Adora was right, Catra would go anywhere with her, live even in a box, because even if Adora didn't know it she was Catra's home. "So, what do you say?"

"Let's do it." Catra grinned and hugged Adora tightly. Leave it to the blonde to make her forget about all her problems in five minutes, even it is for at least ten. A breeze hit both of them and Adora visibly shivered.

"Come on, let's head inside. I don't want you to get sick." She stood up and offered her hand to Catra, who stared at it and shook her head.

"I'm not sleepy yet." She rubbed her arms and Adora leaned down to take one of her hands.

"I know. We'll watch one of those soap operas you have downloaded. Teresa is kind of hot." They both giggle and Catra stood up.

"But your Spanish sucks. You can barely understand them." Catra dusted herself off. "Besides you're still drugged. You'll fall asleep as soon as I press play."

"That's why you're teaching me. And I won't!" Adora giggled as they made their way down.

Catra was right, Adora fell asleep as soon as she pressed play. She didn't mind, though, cuddling Adora quickly had become her

second favorite hobby.

It didn’t take much time to leave either. The next day Catra was scouting the train station and coming up with a way to sneak into the trains since the tickets were beyond expensive. Adora packed what they needed in backpacks in the meantime, securing the money inside them with the addition of the one Catra got from selling the brass knuckles for a pretty high price. Three days later they were sitting on their first train, a few hours later in their first motel and life went on like this for a year. They never heard of Octavia or Weaver again, didn’t care for Georgia anymore. What mattered was exploring the cities, sneaking into the observatory sites, and sit until the stars disappeared from the sky. Catra would teach Adora Spanish and the constellations and grew excited when she managed to find them with ease. For these months everything was peaceful and even Catra’s mind was mostly at ease from Weaver. Somedays the nightmares would come at full force, and the voiced would remind her that she’d probably never be free of her and that Adora was bound to leave her; that she was just a phase in her life.

However, Catra noticed a detail in Adora as the days went by that made her forget all about it. Whenever they were looking up at the stars, Catra noticed the way Adora’s eyes would linger on her face, especially where her freckles rested across her nose to her cheeks. She wondered if Adora was connecting her own constellations on them, finally finding the beauty that Catra started seeing on the blonde every single day.

A big part of her wished she was, at least.

Chapter End Notes

> Was dying to post a chapter in this fic. I did mention they'd be slow but I didn't anticipate how slow. xd Sorry about that.

Enough

Chapter by Histmex

Chapter Notes

TW for drugs and injuries.

The chapter count is tentative for now but it might go up.

June *2139.*

(15 months later.)

"Come on, Adora. Chop it!"

"Are you sure we can't find another solution? Your hair is so pretty."

"Adora, part of it is literally matted."

"But I can use a brush-" Adora got cut off when Catra suddenly spun around and grabbed the barber clippers from her hand.

"I'll literally buzz it off if you don't cut it." She threatened with a teasing undertone and Adora sighed in response, a small smile plastered on her face. She took the machine from Catra and decided to put it on the table and grab the scissors.

"We could've gone to a real hairstylist you know." Adora mumbled and pulled up a piece of Catra's hair, showing her how she cut it on the bathroom mirror.

Catra smiled happily when she cut it short. Sure she'll miss her hair, but the mess that it was right now was unbearable. Apparently traveling for a year straight and not really taking care of it as she should, led to Catra's somewhat curly hair being

unhealthy and even matted in some areas. Not that it was super healthy, to begin with, but at least she could use the cheap curly hair products in the comfort of their old warehouse. During their travels, they usually didn't have a stable shower, and whenever they could wash thoroughly, Catra wouldn't pay much attention to her hair routine other than shampoo and conditioner. Now she was facing the consequences of her actions, not being able to handle it or Adora's rough brushing anymore and just want it *off* . She bought cheap clippers downtown and simply placed them in front of Adora before going out for a job. "Either you do it or I will." she told the blonde who didn't believe her. It wasn't until Catra gave herself an eyebrow slit that Adora took the clippers off her hands.

"Why would I need a hairstylist when I have you." Catra smiled at her through the mirror and could see Adora blushing slightly while cutting her hair. Little details like that never calmed down the feelings she had for Adora, even worse when she was just a twelve-year-old. However, one thing she could say for certain. Her feelings for Adora were way more than a hormonal crush for the blonde, coming to understand at a young age that she had truly loved Adora since they were children. She realized now, after cuddling with Adora as they usually did every night and running her fingers down the scars on her jaw, that she would love her forever; even if a deep part of her believed that she didn't deserve Adora.

"Is this enough?" Adora asked her and Catra shook her now neck-length shaggy hair. She ran her hand through it, but still felt it rough and frowned.

"Shorter." Catra sighed and ignored the pieces of her once middle-back long hair on the floor. Adora nodded and bit her tongue in concentration as she cut shorter, and Catra closed her eyes. After a few moments, she felt Adora lean away.

"I really don't want to cut it shorter, but if you want to we can." When she opened her eyes, the first thing Catra noticed was Adora grinning like an idiot. Her eyes then fell to her hair and

gasped. Adora had left her with a shaggy pixie cut that felt great in between her fingers. She shook her head, making it look messy. “Do you like it?” Catra grinned.

“It’s perfect.” She stood up and faced Adora with a grateful smile. “Thank you.” They stared at each other for a few moments before Adora broke eye contact.

“You’re welcome.” She reached over to pet through Catra’s hair. “It suits you.” Catra cleared her throat and stepped away.

“Well, now I need products to actually maintain it so let’s go see what Seahawk wants so I can buy them.”

Settling down somewhere for a brief moment was something that both of them wanted at this point. Sure, traveling across the country by train-hopping, stealing to earn their keep, and spending the night in abandoned observatories and fields so they could watch the stars had been fulfilling these past months -and surely Catra could throw in a cheesy remark that she would never say out loud about how Adora was her home-, but the concept of *home* was beyond a bit unfamiliar to the two. Yes, Catra could think that silly remark all she wanted, but even if she felt that way about Adora… the truth is that she also wanted a place to call home *with* Adora. The closest they had to that was the warehouse, not even Weaver’s house was considered a home especially since it still haunted the two of them, but they had left both places behind without thinking twice. They both wanted somewhere they weren’t afraid nor had the need of leaving.

Walking around the failed cyber city on their way to Sea Hawk’s restaurant, Catra seemed to realize now why she was so drawn to it when they first got here. As much as they hated the idea, and promised themselves to not get laced with technology, Catra had to admit that her curiosity for that life was at its peak, quickly finding herself wanting more Los Angeles was the only city that had a direct train to Oregon that was the only access to Republic City, and Catra hadn’t been able to take her mind off that since she saw a poster of the city at an old bus stop. *Republic City: The*

Future is now, it read along with some information and the sponsor of the publicity. Catra thought often about telling Adora that she wanted to go there, but when they got to their small shitty apartment and Adora seemed beyond happy to finally be settled down, Catra didn't have the heart to tell her; especially when her desired destination required them to get at least basic software. How would she even?

"Hey, Adora...so I know that it's a stupid idea cause we'd probably get implanted right at the border and possibly thrown into jail for trespassing but I want to try and sneak into Republic City."

Yeah, that was surely perfect. Trying to sneak into one of the most protected state borders? Sure, she'll definitely sell that to Adora. It's not like her best friend didn't consider the cozy shitty apartment they managed to get five months ago home already. Catra felt her mouth twitch slightly downwards. That's because it *was* home, it *was* theirs -even though Sea Hawk had offered it after learning that they were living in the alley down in the shady parts of town-, and Adora was with her. Who was her to tell Adora to leave her newfound home? Why did she want to move to Republic City? Why *wasn't* it enough?

"I can hear you thinking." Adora said softly to not startle Catra out of her thoughts and the latter frowned deeper. Catra turned to face her and watched Adora pick a flower from the sidewalk planter and hand it to her, a worried expression on her face. She always did this: hand whatever flower she found to Catra on their walks. The brunette never understood why, and she never attempted to question it with the fear that Adora would stop doing it. Truth was, it made her feel special and always brought a smile to her face, making it hard for her to just not reach for Adora's hand and press their lips together. It was easier to love her in secret, after all, she didn't want to lose this if Adora didn't feel the same. Truth was she didn't know what Adora even wanted, and the question slipped past her lips before she could stop it.

"What do you want, Adora?" Catra asked her, staring down at the small white flower in her hands.

"A cubano from Marco's." No hesitation and a shit-eating grin. Catra laughed.

"You're such a dork." Adora rolled her eyes at her and frowned when Catra's face turned serious. "I mean in life. What do you want?" Adora closed her mouth shut forcefully and her eyebrows furrowed. Oh fuck, *I messed up. Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.* Adora's silence was maddening, it was choking Catra and taking away all of the air from her lungs. Suddenly she couldn't breathe, even more, when Adora stopped abruptly in front of Seahawk's restaurant.

Only one thought distracted her from Adora's intense gaze.

A pirate-themed restaurant? It's only funny when the owner doesn't believe he's a pirate too and sings shanties all the time.

"Catra, my life revolves around you. Whatever you want to do, I'll do." Holy fucking shit. Who the fuck says that? "But-" and there it is… "I like L.A. a lot...we have our own place and stuff...I just want to settle down for a bit, make a life here and...get an *actual* job…" Though she seemed hesitant, Catra could tell that Adora had been thinking about this for quite a bit. It made her heart clench, mostly because Adora was the only person Catra couldn't be selfish with. She would do anything for Adora. She would die for Adora. She would *kill* for Adora whoever dared to hurt her, this one she was certain of; a wicked idea already forming in her head, one that would surely create a divide between them but she needed to do.

She would sacrifice her own happiness for Adora's.

"If that makes you happy, we'll do it." Catra finally responded with the best smile she could put on but Adora could see through it, and Catra noticed this. She quickly opened the door to the restaurant and walked in, cutting their conversation short.

"Oh if it isn't my favorite dynamic duo!" Seahawk immediately yelled from his place at the cash register, a bundle of money in each hand. Catra grumbled in annoyance and Adora chuckled.

Yes, she was thankful for the help he had given them and all the contacts he managed to get them, but wow was he insufferable at times. “Catra you got your haircut! You’re looking *fantastic.* So do you, Adora!” The blonde laughed.

“Hey, Seahawk.” She plopped down on one of the stools, Catra sitting next to her and giving Seahawk a small wave. “Catra told me you have something for us?”

“Ah yes! A nice and easy job indeed. This would be easier if you two had a phone, though.” Catra shook her head. No phones. That was her only rule. Seahawk understood and shrugged. “Alright, here’s the deal.”

The guy wanted lighter fluid.

Fucking lighter fluid!

And it wasn’t a damn small bottle. No. Dude wanted *gallons* of the stuff. Catra chose to ignore Adora’s remarks about accepting this job and giving such a powerful liquid to a possible arsonist and just focused on driving his pickup truck to the place they were getting it from. Catra had to admit that the Dragon’s Daughter was a nice pick-up, easy to drive and figure out without former experience. It was quite fun, and it was nice to imagine this was the 300zx back in Georgia-

Focus on the job .

It was a beyond simple job too. Catra scouted the high-end retail store and the area where the containers with the merchandise should be. There were a few cameras, which shouldn’t be a problem since they couldn’t get scanned and recognized (which they don’t know now, but Adora later learns that they *can* still end up in the wanted list the hard way) so they parked the truck with the back against the fence and jumped over.

The job was going great also. They found the container Seahawk had mentioned, opened it, and took out the ten boxes full of gallons of the stuff to the fence. The only problem was that it was

taking too long. The boxes were beyond heavy and getting them from one place to another was quite difficult considering they were scrawny kids who survived off canned food and the occasional strong meal. Catra was standing on the cargo bed and putting down the boxes Adora was handing her from across the fence down when the alarm suddenly rang out. *Fuck* .

"Adora, leave the box! We gotta go!" Catra hissed when she saw Adora reaching for the final box on the floor and attempting to climb up the crate she had set up. The blonde groaned with effort, her arms already tired from all the heavy lifting.

"It's just one box." Adora groaned out, slowly lifting the box towards Catra. The brunette's heart was pounding hard against her chest, already hearing the sirens in the distance and the slight flash of red and blue. "Catra, I can't." Catra looked over at Adora and saw her resting the box between her torso and the fence.

"Then leave it!"

"We need the cut!"

"Fucking shit." Catra grumbled and quickly climbed up the fence, straddling it and ignoring the pain of the wires stabbing at her thighs, and reaching for the box Adora was shakingly handing to her. The sirens were getting closer, and now Adora heard them too. The brunette jumped down and placed the box on the bed, not paying attention to Adora struggling to climb up and getting caught on the wires. It wasn't until Adora hit the concrete floor with a strained cry and the red and blue lights were visible that Catra turned to look at her.

"Adora!" She quickly jumped off the cargo bed and helped the blonde stand up.

"I'm fine." Adora mumbled and let Catra help her onto her seat on the truck. That's when Catra saw the distinct shade of red contrasting Adora's white shirt and suppressed a whimper. Damn it, she must've gotten hurt with the fence. She shook her head

and quickly got on her seat, taking off at full speed just in time before the cops arrived. The drive was silent for a few minutes before Adora winced loudly again.

“Does it hurt?” Catra stole a quick glance at Adora, who had her shirt up and was inspecting the wound. It was quite gnarly, blood getting everywhere including her hand.

“No, it tickles actually.” Catra rolled her eyes. This idiot. She fell for this idiot. Her breath hitched. Now wasn’t the time.

“Don’t get blood on the seat. I’m taking you to a doct-”

“No.” Catra glanced at Adora with clear exasperation but the blonde simply shook her head. “We deliver the stuff to Seahawk then walk home so you can patch me up.” The look of determination on Adora’s face let Catra know that there was no room for argument. After a few moments, they reached a red light and Catra started tugging her long sleeve black shirt off. She had a tank top underneath and Adora needed to change shirts.

“Take your shirt off.”

“So demanding.” Catra rolled her eyes again and threw her shirt at Adora just as the light turned green. Adora could be so difficult at times.

“Just put this on and apply pressure to the cut with the dirty one. I don’t want to pay Seahawk extra because his seats got stained.” Adora only nodded before starting to change.

“Can we stop by Marco’s before going home? We need a celebratory cubano eating contest after we get paid.” Adora wiggled her eyebrows and Catra chuckled, noticing the pained expression she was trying to hide.

“You and Marco have a weird fucking bond.” Adora giggled at that. “We aren’t having an eating contest with a hole in your hip.”

“But Catra…”

“Hmm?”

“...I want sandwiches…” The brunette laughed again at Adora’s sad tone and puppy eyes, slowly easing up the tension in her body.

“Tomorrow we’ll get some, okay? Right now we need to fix you up.” Adora beamed at her.

“You promise?”

“I promise.”

By the time they reached Seahawk and got their cut, Adora’s wound had stopped mostly bleeding, making her walk home a bit more bearable. It was slow-paced, but Catra didn’t mind. As long as she was with Adora, time was nonexistent for her, especially when she was about to see her favorite thing in the world. Whenever they walked home from “work”, Adora would change routes and go down to this small jewelry store, and tonight -even with a bleeding gash on her hip- wasn’t the exception. It all started the day they walked past it and saw the very necklace they were staring at now from the window. It was a gold chain with a small gold horse charm on it, and it drove Adora crazy. The first time she saw it she squealed, now she just gapes at it with hearts in her eyes. The only problem was the price.

Catra could only watch her as Adora’s eyes filled with amazement and hope.

“Isn’t it beautiful?” Adora turned to look at her, not knowing that Catra’s eyes had been on her the entire time.

“Beyond beautiful.”

They got to the apartment a few minutes later and Catra basically pushed Adora to the shower to get her cleaned and stitched up. After arguing for a solid ten minutes because Adora didn’t want Catra to stitch her wound, even though the thing was a straight-up gash that crossed her hip and side, Catra relented and simply

put some bandages on it. They then decided to try and watch some episodes of their latest telenovela. Adora's Spanish was getting better, and Catra appreciated all the work she put into it after the brunette expressed her fear of losing the language. They even spoke it from time to time between them, and it made Catra beam every time Adora spoke fluently. Because of the cocktail of painkillers and antibiotics that Catra made her drink, though, Adora soon passed out on their shared bed halfway through an episode with her arms around Catra. As usual, the brunette was softly trailing the scars on her jaw with her thumb and taking her details in. Adora was simply beyond beautiful to her and she could admire the once soft features as much as she liked. Although their diet wasn't the best, Adora was filling out and Catra noticed it every day.

Her once soft jaw was slowly becoming chiseled, she was getting taller than Catra -which she secretly debated if she liked it or not-, her lips were fuller and a beautiful shade of pink, her eyelashes were always long but now covered small eyebags, her chest, her hands; everything about Adora was changing before her and Catra found her more beautiful as the days passed. Yet, what really captivated Catra nowadays about Adora -besides her body, sue her- was the way Adora's eyes went from a soft and innocent baby blue to once that sometimes burnt with such intensity that they melted Catra to the ground. They were simply so expressive, so deep; and when they burnt with cold passion over something, Catra wanted to play with that blue fire. Adora's eyes held every emotion she was now discovering she could feel, and Catra was a witness to all of them.

Her thumb trolled softly to Adora's lips and she sighed softly. There was nothing that the brunette wanted to do than make them pull up in a smile; kissing her was a close second. She thought of earlier and frowned lightly. Catra really wanted to get Adora the necklace for her birthday, but she couldn't with her 50% split low-cut jobs. Maybe Adora and her could buy it together? Maybe it wouldn't mean as much, but that wouldn't matter as long as the blonde was sporting it.

Adora stirred in her sleep and furrowed her eyebrows.

“Catra…” She mumbled and Catra stilled her thumb.

“Hmm...?”

“I got a job at a diner. I start in two days.” Adora breathed out and further buried herself against Catra, nuzzling her face against her neck. Catra was too in shock to process, then let out a small sound of discontent.

She didn’t get why she was upset. Well, she *did,* but she shouldn’t be. Adora seemed to be happy, that’s all that should matter, right? Now she apparently had a job, they had an apartment, decent food, and a stable money source. Adora was actually putting work into this whole thing, clearly attempting to clean her actions and attempting the morally good life; all while Catra didn’t even know what to do with *her* life. She could always ask Adora to find her a similar job, but that made her frown deeper. That would surely end her. There was no adrenaline, no rush, no danger in a normal daytime job like Adora’s. She still wanted all that and more.

Her thumb started moving again against Adora’s jaw.

Catra wanted to do this while Adora was awake. Buy Adora the hella expensive necklace. Take her out on dates and hold her hand while they share a milkshake by the beach. To start doing heists and pulling them off together, climbing up the food chain and coming on top. Catra wanted to be on top, to prove to herself that Weaver’s words weren’t true; that she wasn’t the useless child she made her believe she was and that she could be more. She wanted the upper hand with Adora by her side as something more than just best friends. Catra’s eyes flickered to Adora’s lips. She wanted all that. Yet, she partly found herself content right where she was. Adora’s arms were always her favorite place. The apartment was Adora’s home, but her arms were Catra’s. She could learn to settle for this conformity and breathe in Adora’s scent every night until the day Adora decided to replace her spot with someone else that actually deserved her.

As much as she tried, she couldn’t quiet the selfish primal part of her that aspired for possible greatness.

Why couldn’t she just be happy in Adora’s warmth like this? Why did she have to want more?

Why isn’t it enough?

With all of this in mind, and her mission to now buy the necklace for Adora -since her new job surely wouldn’t pay as much as they got paid now- Catra snuck out of Adora’s arms in the morning and went to speak with Seahawk. She walked by the jewelry store on her way there and saw the necklace still on display and went inside. After much convincing, and flashing a few dollar bills, the lady agreed on pulling it out of the display and set up a payment plan for Catra. There was no way she was letting someone else get their hands on it. With that done, she quickly made her way to Seahawk’s restaurant and was delighted when he found him there; sitting on one of the tables and filling up a lighter with the lighter fluid from last night.

“Ah, Catra! Always so good to see-” He began speaking, still focused on his work.

“I need more money.” She interrupted Seahawk and he turned to look at her. “I don’t care what you want me to do, I need a bigger cut.”

“Is Adora not with you?” He put the lighter down and leaned back on his chair.

“No. I don’t want her to know.” This is for her. “This is between you and me.” Anything for Adora’s and her happiness.

You can always kill two birds with one stone, right?

Seahawk studied her for a moment, twirling his mustache around his index finger. “You’d do anything?” Catra suddenly felt sick to her stomach.

“Anything.” Seahawk nodded, and Catra felt uneasy about how his goofiness seemed to completely disappear right now. He leaned back further and put his hand on his pocket, pulling out and placing on the table a small one-ounce crystal bottle filled with liquid.

“What do you know about VHS?”

Signing a deal with the devil always had consequences, and Catra ran through hers on her way home. On top of the list? Adora’s wrath when she realized that Catra had committed to dealing drugs and other stuff. She laughed softly at the irony. They both started new jobs tomorrow it seemed. Another consequence was going to be the guilt that was about to consume her mind. She knew what drugs could do to people, she had seen it first hand on many occasions in Georgia, and heard the stories of the kids in the orphanage whose parents abused substances. Catra knew she was about to become the main distributor of these addictions, all to feed her need to become someone. Catra would argue and try to calm her conscience saying that she at least wasn’t a killer. Adora would then argue back that she didn’t need to go down this path to do just that, but what else could Catra do? Be better? At first, you don’t believe it, but you can only be told that you’ll never be better or enough a few times before it imprints in your head, especially when it was accompanied by a leather belt.

Besides, that would make Adora a hypocrite. She had been in this life with her for years now.

When Catra got back to her apartment, Adora was sitting up on their bed rubbing her eyes and looking around. Her heart skipped a beat when Adora found her and gave her a warm smile, reaching for her and motioning for her to get on the bed. After taking her shoes off, Catra did just that and sighed in delight when Adora pulled her to cuddle against her. At moments like this, Catra felt that small contentment and could imagine that this would always be her life with Adora by her side.

“Where did you go?” Adora mumbled with her voice heavy with sleep, her eyes closed. Catra winced slightly, forcing the lie out of her lips.

“Just went out for a walk.” Adora nodded and groaned.

“I don’t know what you gave me last night, but I don’t think I’ll be able to get up today. You trying to kill me or something?” Catra laughed and shook her head.

“I may have given you Advil pm and antibiotics so your wound doesn’t get infected and you could sleep.”

“We have to change the bandages.” Catra lifted the hem of Adora’s tank top and checked the somewhat bloody bandage. She put her shirt down and looked back at Adora’s face.

“They’re okay for now. Just try and sleep more, okay? You need to if you’re gonna start work tomorrow.” Adora’s eyes shot open halfway at that and she frowned.

“I’m sorry I didn’t tell you sooner. I should’ve. It’s going to change everything, and we have an apartment to pay, and the initial paycheck won’t be enough; so I was thinking of still working-”

“Shh…” Catra cut off Adora’s nervous rambling and saw her eyebrows furrowing. “Don’t worry. We’ll figure it out, we always do. I promise.” Adora nodded at this and stayed silent for a couple of moments. Catra thought she had fallen asleep, but she spoke again.

“You owe me a bigass sandwich.” Catra laughed loudly at that.

“You’re such an idiot.”

You'd do better

Chapter Notes

TW very slight reference to child abuse

2140 (One year later)

Even after years of living and traveling together, Adora found some of Catra's actions a luxury. They were simply so uncommon, only reserved for when Catra was in that relaxed headspace, which wasn't a lot with how constant her nightmares of Weaver were getting. She'd wake up Adora in the middle of the night squirming and whimpering, her cheeks stained with tears and her teeth clenched. Adora dealt with the normal ones the same way she did years ago -waking her up gently and bringing her back to her chest to cuddle-, but she still couldn't figure out why they were so frequent lately. Regardless, the nights that Catra had a good night's sleep draped across Adora's chest she woke up in good moods and would sometimes sing and dance in the kitchen while making food, or even read to Adora from one of the illegal books she acquired on her tablet. Today seemed to be the mood for the latter.

Catra was laying on their bed on her back with her tablet in her hands while Adora laid on her legs by the foot of the bed with her eyes closed. Catra's voice was also a luxury for her. Adora noticed the way it seemed to be maturing, turning raspier and overall deeper, and she would sometimes joke about the cracks. Yet, there was nothing she enjoyed more than Catra reading to her just to hear her speak.

"¿Qué es la vida? Una ilusión,una sombra, una ficción, y el mayor bien es pequeño…" [What is this life? A frenzy, an illusion. A shadow, a delirium, a fiction.The greatest good but little, and this life..]

Well...there was certainly something.

“que toda la vida es sueño,y los sueños, sueños son.” [Is but a dream, and dreams are only dreams.]

Catra’s smile, which seemed to be making Adora’s breath hitch lately. The one she was looking at now that she opened her eyes and they were locked with Catra’s.

“Beautiful.” Adora sighed out and furrowed her eyebrow slightly. Truth is, she didn’t know if she was referring to the poem, her voice, her eyes, or the way she read it but, when Catra smiled wider and blushed slightly, Adora decided it was all of the above. In fact, she also realized she wants to see more of it.

“I got this for you...I was saving it until Christmas but…” Adora stood up and met Catra’s curious gaze as she knelt on the floor.

“Christmas is a month away, dummy. You really couldn’t wait?” Adora giggled at the teasing tone and poked her head from under the bed.

“Trust me. When you see it, you’ll thank me for not waiting. You’ll love it.” That she was certain of and, as she rose from the floor with the gift, she knew she made the right choice. Catra gaped at her as she gently placed the guitar case on the bed and sat next to it with a hopeful smile. The younger girl sat up from her spot, putting the tablet aside, and reaching for the case; opening it to reveal a 1989 black Gibson Les Paul, similar to the one back at Octavia's. Catra let out a shuddering breath as she carefully ran her fingers along the neck.

“How did you get this?” Catra whispered and looked up at Adora, who smiled sheepishly. At her silence, Catra frowned. “ *Adora…”*

“Seahawk helped me.” Catra frowned deeper and Adora’s eyebrows furrowed. This was the opposite of what she was looking for. “Catra…”

“I know how much you hate pulling these things off. You didn’t have to do this.” Adora’s lip slightly quirked up and she reached over to take Catra’s hand.

“I did it ‘cause I knew that it’d make you happy. I know these past few weeks have been...stressful for you.” Catra bit her lip and let out a sigh.

“You didn’t have to do that for me.” Adora looked at her with determination, her mouth in a firm line again.

“Catra, I would do anything for you.” She stopped for a second and took a deep breath. “I would kill or get myself killed to protect you.” Catra’s eyes widened.

“Don’t say that.” She huffed. “You’re always so dramatic. How did we go from you stealing a hella expensive guitar to you killing people?” They both laughed and Adora shrugged.

“Because it’s true! Stealing a guitar is nothing compared to what I would do for you.” Catra had stopped laughing and was staring at Adora with fondness and sweetness. Adora thought she might melt beneath Catra’s gaze, always so intense with fire buried beneath her mismatched eyes.

“I’d do anything for you too.” She poked Adora’s forehead and kept her finger there for a moment before teasingly pushing Adora’s head back. “Since we are exchanging gifts, I got something for you. Don’t worry. I didn’t steal it, unlike you.” Catra stood up and reached behind the bed frame, ignoring Adora poking her tongue out at her. As opposed to Adora’s big gift, Catra’s gift was considerably smaller; a small white cardboard box with a yellow ribbon tied around it. She gave it to Adora, and sat next to her as the blonde opened it with shaky hands; exposing a golden chain with a charm of a horse dangling from it. Adora’s jaw fell open and she turned to look at Catra with tears in her eyes.

“I’m guessing you like it- oof!” Catra was interrupted by Adora’s crushing hug and the blonde pulled back with a grin. “Want me to put it on?” She didn’t have to ask twice and Adora was with her back to her, holding her ponytail out of the way as Catra fastened the chain in place.

Adora really didn't know how Catra could afford the chain. All she knew is that Catra was still working for Seahawk while Adora was working at a diner downtown. She was gone most of the day, every day getting off work and being greeted by Catra to go get their favorite sandwiches, so she really didn't know *when* Catra worked. Worse yet, she didn't know *where* Catra went, only figuring out that she had picked up the habit of smoking from somewhere along the way when she found the box of cigarettes one day. She had asked her about the whole thing before, only earning a shrug from the younger girl and a "same old same old".

Adora wasn't about to let her curiosity ruin the moment, though, so she focused on spending this last hour before she had to work listening to Catra trying out her guitar. It was bliss -if you don't count the winces whenever Catra made the guitar protest- and Adora dreaded getting up and announcing she was going to work but she did. Catra surprised her when she said she was going to work as well, and hopped on the shower while Adora settled on changing. The blonde let out a sound of protest when she realized her jeans had a hole in them and sighed.

"Catra?!" She called out, hearing a questioning sound from the bathroom. "I'm borrowing your jeans! Mine have a hole in them!" It wasn't really her asking for permission since she was already pulling them on, but she wasn't about to steal them without letting her know. Adora groaned trying to wiggle into the suddenly small jeans -assuming she was gaining weight from eating at the diner and carrying food crates all day- when something hit the carpeted floor. She knows Catra said something in the shower but she was focused on the small crystal bottle that was laying on the floor unmoving, pale green liquid filling most of it. Her face contoured in confusion and she leaned down to pick up the small bottle and studied it.

What the hell?

"Adora?" She heard from behind her and Adora turned around to face her. Catra widened her eyes lightly at the scowl Adora wore and more when she saw Adora's hand. In a normal setting, Adora

would gawk at her for only being in a towel. Now...well now Adora was feeling a blinding mixture of confusion and anger. She wasn't oblivious, she *knew* what this was but, why did Catra have it?

"What is this doing in your pocket?" The blonde gritted out and Catra looked between the bottle and her blue eyes a few times settling on the guarded expression she wore after a nightmare.

"It's none of your business." Catra reached for it and Adora recoiled back. "Adora-"

"Are you using?" Catra looked at her in disbelief.

"No!" Adora's mouth fell slightly open.

"You're selling it?!" Silence. Suddenly all the money Catra was spending on *good* groceries and other luxuries made sense. The clothes, the new hair products for her growing hair, *the chain* . Adora's fingers gripped on it in silent inquiry and Catra merely nodded. "What the hell, Catra?!"

"You can't judge me for this." Catra growled at her and took the bottle from her. Adora frowned deeper and crossed her arms, looking away while Catra changed quickly.

"I'm not judging you. I'm worried about you. It's one thing to steal but to sell drugs?!" Catra froze halfway through buttoning her jeans.

"Thank God you're not judging. I wouldn't have guessed you were trying not to." Adora went to protest but Catra's glare silenced her. "Listen, you can judge me all you want. I could care less, but don't forget this was your life too."

"I never sold drugs to make a living!" Adora threw her hands up. "This is all you! First is drugs then what? Seahawk is gonna ask you to kill-"

"Seahawk won't ask me to kill anyone!" Catra put on a shirt angrily and threw one at Adora. She suddenly looked hurt. "You

really think I'm capable of that?" Adora's expression softened and she sagged slightly.

"Of course I don't, but Catra you don't have to do this. We can always find a way." Adora tried to reach for her but Catra winced back, a shadow crossing her face.

"It won't be enough, Adora." Her voice let out a small crack, the first one Adora didn't smile to. She reached over for the small bottle and placed it in her pocket. "Nothing is enough…" With that, she was gone, and Adora stood in the room with tears rolling down her cheeks while listening to the front door opening and closing forcefully.

So much for not ruining the moment.

Adora looked down at the clock in the nightstand then at the -now- skinny jeans with a sour expression. Her shift at work went even worse. She couldn't focus, she tripped many times and got orders wrong left and right. If it wasn't for Angella's kindness, and the fact that someone made an old lady fall to the floor, Adora swore she would've gotten fired on the spot. Her mind just couldn't wrap her head around the whole thing. Did Catra fall that low? Her face contoured when she was cleaning one of the tables in pain and she frowned. *Was she not enough?* And then the next question hit her like a tidal wave. *Would she ever be enough?* She knew Catra had problems expressing herself but damn...this was just worse than getting shot on the thigh, she assumed. Adora wasn't naive either. She looked down at the tray in her hand with a frown, feeling the weight of the chain in her neck. Catra could be right about one thing. Truth was, Adora's salary wouldn't be enough; even if they both worked it still wouldn't be enough to eat and live as well as they did currently. And, truthfully? Could Adora even scowl at Catra for her new job? If you could even call it that, of course. It's not like the girl knew how to do other stuff.

That didn't mean that she couldn't learn, though; and that's exactly what seemed to bother Adora. The blonde knew Catra could be and do better, so why didn't she? Was the fear of Catra

doing worse so unjustified? Catra once asked Adora what she wanted. Now she knew she wanted to talk about all of this calmly. What did *Catra* want, though?

Adora wanted to ask her when she got done working, she tried to get out early from her shift but couldn't. Her stomach turned into nuts suddenly, the need to go check on Catra increasing by the minute. She let out a loud sigh of relief when her shift finally ended and Angella laughed at her when she hung her apron.

"Surely it wasn't that bad." Angella rolled her eyes, walking Adora to the exit. The blonde found herself chuckling.

"It was just busy and I'm exhausted." She brushed it off with a polite smile and stepped out in the cold air of the city. It was noticeable that winter was falling upon them and Adora loved it.

"Mhmm." Angella hummed. "And you sure that's all there is to it." Adora looked up at her boss feeling her smile faltering under her gaze.

Angella was amazing, she had taken her in when Adora stumbled into her diner with the ad she had put up printed on her hands. At first, Angella turned her down because of the paperwork and everything else she was missing, but after Adora rambled out of her situation Angella ended up not only giving her a job but free food to take home whenever Adora needed it. It was nice, Adora would always be thankful and wondered if this is what a motherly love would feel like in normal situations. In fact, on many occasions she often wondered if this was the real reason she was so desperate for Catra to take the job as well; to feel that motherly-like bond for the first time in her life after Weaver. She had even brought her to the diner many times to meet Angella but it just wouldn't work.

Unfortunately, letting Angella in let her read Adora like an open book. Adora put her hands inside her pockets, swaying on her stance slightly.

“Just had an argument with Catra, to be honest...I wanted to get out to look for her. She surely doesn’t want to talk to me right now.” Angella nodded in acknowledgment and sighed, hugging her arms around herself.

“Young couples. Always arguing.” Adora looked at her wide-eyed, a blush already forming on her cheeks and stuttering words until Angella laughed. “Don’t worry. I’m messing with you.” She grinned down at Adora, who huffed in annoyance.

“It’s not funny.” She tried to hide her smile but Angella put her hand on her shoulder reassuringly. Adora looked up to see a serious expression on Angella’s face.

“I’m sure that whatever happened you two can figure it out. I can tell you love each other a lot. Surely it’s just a misstep.” Angella smirked. “Besides, I don’t think you’ll have to look for her.” Adora furrowed her eyebrows in confusion and Angella stepped slightly off the side. Adora’s eyes focused behind her and couldn’t help the small smile that plastered itself on her lips.

Catra.

“Thank you.” Adora looked back at Angella and the older woman returned her smile.

“Take care of each other.” She squeezed Adora’s arm before stepping back inside.

Catra was leaning against a light post smoking a cigarette and watching Adora make her way across the street towards her. Adora was, needless to say, relieved to see Catra waiting for her as per usual; especially when she thought that she wouldn’t see her after the fight. Catra’s gaze shifted momentarily downwards when Adora finally reached her.

“I hate when you smoke.” That was a greeting she wasn’t sure she should be giving today considering the circumstances, but she waved that thought off mentally when Catra gave her the usual small smirk and offered the cigarette. The thing is that Adora

couldn’t hold her smoke in at all, so when she coughed out almost immediately after inhaling, Catra chuckled and stomped the cigarette to the ground. She stared at it during the few moments of silence that fell between them and dropped her smile.

“Can we talk..?” It was almost a whisper but Adora picked it up all too well. She didn’t know if the intensity of Catra’s gaze or the three words made her heart race but right now it didn’t matter, not when she noticed the duffle back laying next to Catra’s feet. “I uh...I almost left...I couldn’t...I needed to talk to you.” That just made Adora’s panic settle in quicker. *Catra wanted to leave?* “I couldn’t...leave- Ugh. This isn’t coming outright.” Catra bit her thumb and started fidgeting in her spot. Adora swallowed and took a deep breath.

“Let’s walk to Marco’s, okay..? You can gather your thoughts and I can gather mine on the way there.” Adora offered her hand and Catra looked down at it with furrowed eyebrows.

“I’ve been collecting my thoughts for like an hour, you know. I just...can’t say them.” Adora didn’t drop her hand at the hesitance. She knew Catra had a problem with vulnerability since forever. She was never *allowed* to show it and later didn’t allow herself to express it. Helping Catra, though, settled some of Adora’s panic.

“Hey…” Catra looked up from her hand and they locked eyes. “You can talk to me, you know that.” Catra searched her face for a small while then quickly took Adora’s hand.

It was always like this since they were children. Whenever Weaver laid her hands on Catra and Adora couldn’t stop it, the younger girl would find comfort in Adora’s embrace. Over the years that never changed, Adora’s touch meant safety to her -she had said once- and whenever she had it Catra felt the freedom to be well...this. Her entire demeanor changed, her eyes softened, and she let out a deep breath as she squeezed Adora’s hand and picked up her bag with the other. As they walked to the food

truck, Adora felt herself getting more nervous and kept squeezing Catra's hand.

Would she really have left? This surely had an explanation, right?

"I want to go to Republic City." Catra blurted out after a few steps of silent walking and Adora stopped dead in her tracks. They stared at each other and her eyebrows furrowed. *Republic City?* "L.A...isn't enough…" Adora's breath hitched the words for earlier pounding on her ears. She bit her lip and threatened to let go of Catra's hand but the younger girl tightened her grip. Adora looked down at the floor.

"Am I not enoug-" The sound of the duffle bag hitting the floor and Catra gripping her wrists cut her off. Adora looked up to see Catra's mismatched eyes pleading at her, an apology dancing behind them.

"This isn't your fault." Catra whispered and Adora bit her lip. There it was. The reassurance and the indirect apology.

"You were going to leave, Catra." Catra shrunk a bit in her stance at Adora's tone. She couldn't help it. "After I told you this morning that I'd do anything for you."

"Adora, I thought I was doing you a favor *because* of this morning." Catra's voice was thick with desperation. A few bypassers stared at them oddly, but neither cared. They had to have this conversation. It was now or never. "I thought it was better if I left."

"What would I ever do without you?" Adora whispered and Catra shook her head.

"You'd do better." Adora was about to protest but Catra spoke again. "I don't know what I would do without you, though." She swallowed. "I want you to come with me."

"And if I don't want to?"

“Then we’ll stay and figure things out.”

Adora could only stare at Catra.

Leaving L.A. wasn’t in her plans at all. She actually loved it here, or maybe she loved that they had finally settled down- she didn’t know but she still loved it. They had an apartment, they had jobs, though Adora hated Catra’s. What if leaving *was* good for Catra? What if Republic City helped turn their lives around? She looked down to Catra’s hands still holding onto her wrists. *Was that the solution?* Adora then wondered if she would do better without Catra but the more her gears turned the more she realized that she didn’t want to find out.

Negotiate it, she thought.

“If we leave you turn your life around.” Catra frowned slightly when they locked eyes. “We both work normal jobs and live a normal life.” The one she so craved for. If she was willing to let something of hers she could only hope Catra was willing to do so as well, and she almost smiled when Catra nodded slowly.

“I’d do anything for you, Adora. I’ll never leave you, I promise.” And if Adora wasn’t so overwhelmed with the conversation, she would’ve noticed that this -as Catra’s apologies- was an indirect love confession, just like this morning’s. It was so casual that Adora had missed it. The thought didn’t even cross her mind, she just pulled Catra in and hugged her tightly. This dumbass. How could she have thought about leaving? They pulled back and Adora nudged her, wiping off some tears that spilled during their embrace.

“Can we eat? I’m starving.” Catra chuckled, wiping some tears of her own, and they started walking after she picked up her bag. Adora stretched her hand, offering to carry it for her, but Catra misunderstood and just took it on her own.

“Leave it to you to be hungry after a conversation like that.” Catra rolled her eyes and Adora let out a loud sigh.

“Today’s shift was horrible. One of the waiters spilled a tray and made this old lady fall- Stop laughing!” Catra was wheezing and Adora playfully smacked her. The weight of the conversation had lifted and, even though they still had things to discuss, Adora was actually thankful for it. “Anyway the guy got fired on the spot. Angella offered me his hours…” And there was that heaviness again, at least on Adora’s end. Catra surprised her when she just shrugged.

“Take them.” Her steps turned quicker when she spotted the food truck, basically dragging with her. That didn’t stop Adora from picking an orchid from a nearby sidewalk planter and trying to hand it to Catra. It was tradition at this point and Adora often gifted her orchids and roses from them.

“But we just agreed that we were leaving.”

“My hands are full.” Catra smiled at Adora and the blonde rolled her eyes, placing the orchid on her hair as Catra spoke. “We don’t have to leave now. I want to do this right. Getting into Republic City isn’t easy.”

They reached the food truck and Marco greeted them with a warm smile. The man was simply too sweet, calling them his favorite customers, and always mentioning how Adora’s Spanish was getting better and better. Adora always accepted his compliments proudly and he cheered her on the first time she managed to order for them completely in Spanish. He got them their usual order ready in record time and, as always, the duo promised him they would come back soon. Adora will surely miss him dearly when they leave.

They sat down on a nearby picnic table and ate as they spoke.

“The only way to get into Republic City is through Oregon.” Catra popped a fry into her mouth and swallowed before speaking. Her tablet was between them and she was showing Adora the train routes. “The only train in the country that gets there directly is here. There’s so much flow of people trying to get in that they

regulate it.” Adora stared at the tablet with deep concentration while eating her cubano. She had read about the City lightly. It was almost impossible not to because of how much clients talked about it at work. “The home of cybernetics in the States” they called it, as full of opportunities as it was of crime. Adora shifted uncomfortably in her seat.

They spent the rest of their dinner planning and talking about how they were going to get in and what to do once they did. Catra seemed to have a basic plan laid out. Sure it changed drastically with Adora’s request but if it bothered Catra she didn’t show it. She simply worked around it with expertise, which made Adora question how long she had been planning this. *How long was she unhappy?* And maybe Catra really wasn’t unhappy, just wanted to look for more, and Adora hoped that with all her being. Shadow Weaver left a mark on Catra that Adora has never been able to erase, and truthfully -she thought- it might never be scraped off her mind. Catra needed to learn that she was someone, that she wasn’t useless, and that she was enough. This need to prove that she could be better was always with her and if going to Republic City and finding this life Catra was looking for would satiate it, then Adora would gladly accompany her in her quest to do so.

Still, the nervousness just kept getting worse and, as they laid in their bed that night, Catra noticed. Adora was fidgeting, turning over and throwing and pulling on the sheets; probably bothering the young girl next to her, when Catra turned over and brought Adora to lay on her chest. Adora let out a sigh and rested her head on Catra’s shoulder. Going to a city known for its tech as a “pure” was a bad idea. Angella had warned her about it, that it was illegal to walk around cyberless, and that it could even land her in jail.

“We don’t have to go if you don’t want to.” Catra mumbled softly, threading her fingers through Adora’s hair.

It didn’t matter to the blonde if it was illegal or not. After all…

“We’re going. Besides, if things go south we can always come back and get the apartment from Seahawk.” She felt Catra nodding and wrapped her arms around her tightly.

What were the odds of that happening?

When the world wasn't fair

Chapter by Histmex

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Los Angeles, 2141

"I'm going to a party." Adora looked up from her tablet and raised an eyebrow at Catra. The girl was sitting on the other side of their couch playing soft melodies on her guitar and staring at the clock on the nearby table. It was already 9:00 p.m. Adora let out a small sigh and looked down at the tablet as she spoke.

"As a guest or…" The music stopped.

"Well, I did say I was going to a party not that I got invited to one." Adora looked up to see Catra giving her a playful smirk and she rolled her eyes. She didn't know where Catra learned her sarcasm but she absolutely loved when it let them have these playful banters. "I won't be long. Just sell a few then leave." She shrugged, choosing to ignore how Adora twitched her nose. They had settled on a happy medium but wow did it still bother Adora from time to time, especially since Catra had become so *open* about it. It was a double filed sword, being both thankful and miserable at it but she came to learn that there's not much she can do about it until they leave. After all, this is how they have gotten enough money for their trip.

"I'll go with you then." Catra seemed to open her mouth to protest but Adora shook her head. Catra carried on anyway.

"You work a double shift tomorrow ." The girl stood up and walked to the bedroom to get ready as she spoke. Adora followed. "I don't want you to be late or tired because you decided to come

with me. You need to rest.” Adora leaned against the hallway, watching Catra get ready and averting her gaze when she took her clothes off. She had seen it all but somehow...lately...it felt *different* . Maybe because she wanted to be more than this. Maybe because Adora was already having thoughts of running her hands on Catra. Whatever the case, she wanted to further respect her friend.

“You said you would just sell quickly then we could go. Come on, I have the day off. I want to spend it completely with you.” Adora looked up to see Catra pulling on a black tank top with a flannel on her hands. It went perfectly with the ripped jeans and boots she was wearing. “Please.” Adora pouted and Catra quickly glanced down to her lips then back to her eyes, smirking slightly in a way only Catra knew how to do it. Oh wow. Adora was whipped, wasn’t she? Catra picked something from the drawer then strolled over to the blonde.

“Change before I change my mind.” Catra grinned at her, shoving the t-shirt she had picked up onto Adora’s chest.

She left Adora alone in the room and the blonde quickly walked around getting ready. Cargo pants, the white t-shirt, and her super beat-up converse that she hadn’t even thought about replacing proved to be a satisfying outfit that had Adora hopping on her heels as she walked into the living room. Catra was waiting for her, guitar strapped on her back and counting bills quickly in the middle of the room. Adora took a minute to watch her before Catra noticed her presence and smiled.

“You’re taking the guitar?” Adora tilted her chin to point at it and Catra nodded.

“Just in case, you know?” She put her bundle of cash in one of her pockets and Adora could see the other one full as well. “What if I get bored?” She made her way to the door and opened it, motioning Adora to step before her.

“You’re with me. You’re not supposed to get bored.” Adora rolled her eyes, taking the apartment keys and her wallet before stepping out.

“Mhmm.”

****

The party was in full swing when they got there after a long, peaceful walk. It was under a bridge with a trash can fire as one of its only light sources and a small DJ that was blasting music so loud Adora knew it was only a matter of time before the police arrived. The thought made her uneasy, almost anxious as she thought of the possible scenario of the blues getting there and one of them not being able to outrun them, especially with the guitar she was carrying on her back after insisting Catra let her carry it instead. Adora shoved her hands into her pockets with a deep sigh, watching Catra mingle with the crowd easily and start exchanging. Sometimes she turns a blind eye and looks the other way when she accompanies Catra to these things but this time she wanted to keep her eye on her. Not only because she looks stunning tonight but also because she doesn’t trust the setting. The nearby conversation Catra is having doesn’t help either.

“I didn’t know you were bringing company. Who’s the blonde?” Adora could see Catra shrug, focusing on dealing with someone rather than looking at the guy.

“My roommate.” She simply answered and Adora saw his eyes trailing down the both of them.

“How much to take you both to my apartment?” He had a smirk plastered on his face and Catra slowly looked up at him with a scowl.

To say that Adora had to intervene when Catra’s fist landed on his face was, to say the least.

To say that Catra had gone rabid wolf on the guy, though? It was an understanding.

They walked in silence down the street with only the fainting music, the cars passing by, and their footsteps between them as they made their way home. Adora could tell Catra was mentally grumbling whenever she flexed her hand and winced, and Adora would frown deeply. She thanked whatever force was out there that she was there because things were sure to escalate *more* if she hadn't intervened. Whenever she stole a glance at Catra she could see in her eyes enough anger and disappointment for the both of them so she decided to keep herself calm. There was no use making Catra feel worse, that would never be her objective, not even if she loses her shit. Adora could try to make Catra feel better, though.

"So, did you bring the guitar to hit a bitch with it? I can gift you a bat for that, you know." Adora teased and was relieved when Catra let out an amused scoff. They reached their apartment complex and Catra opened the door for her.

"He had it coming, to be honest. Wasn't the first time he had made comments like that." She explained as they both walked in and she pressed the button for the elevator. "Dude is a fucking creep." Adora scowled at that. How many times had the guy hit on Catra? They stepped in and Catra swatted Adora's hand before she hit the number to their floor and pressed the one to the highest one instead. "The guitar is for the after-party."

Adora gave her a confused eyebrow raise that went completely ignored. Catra slightly leaned against Adora as they waited for the elevator to reach the floor and the blonde sighed, taking Catra's hand to inspect it. It was slowly starting to get swollen and soon would bruise but Adora could tell Catra's hand was okay by the reassuring squeeze she gave the blonde. Adora looked up to see Catra watching her hands with an unreadable expression.

When the elevator announced its arrival to the last floor with a soft *ding* , Catra dragged Adora through the corridors and onto another set of stairs that led to the roof door. Without hesitation, proving that she had done this before, Catra pulled out her small kit from her back pocket and started picking at the lock.

“Catra, what-” The sound of the door opening interrupted Adora and Catra grinned back at her.

Catra motioned with her head at Adora to follow and Adora gasped when they made it to the roof and saw the view. It was beautiful. The roof overlooked the city almost completely, giving them a somewhat clean look of the stars above them. The stars weren’t as impressive as when they saw them on their travels but the mix between city lights and natural lights was perfect. Adora was so in awe she didn’t even notice when Catra took the guitar from her until she heard the soft strums from where she was now sitting on the roof edge.

“Catra, this is beautiful…” Adora breathed out, stood next to her, and put her hands on the edge to catch Catra quickly if she lost balance.

The experimental strumming stopped and Catra turned to look at Adora, making her breath hitch. *Gorgeous* was the only coherent thought that Adora could register on her mind, especially with the intensity of Catra’s gaze. Adora often at times feared the worst about her feelings for Catra. Questions drowned her in a sea of uncertainty more likely than she would like to admit and she only hoped that Catra never noticed her inner struggles when they were together. *What if Catra doesn’t want me? What if she leaves as soon as she finds out? What if I can’t get over her?* Those were only the ones that scratched the surface.

“I found it a week ago. I’ve been trying to find the perfect excuse to bring you here.” Catra mumbled, never tearing her eyes from Adora. It was moments like this that Adora felt hope, that she could allow herself to think that Catra wanted her *this way* . Her words, her intensive gaze, the way her heart sometimes beats quickly when Adora pulled her close either to hug or cuddle her. When she was so attentive, caring, charming, humorous, cunning...The list could go on forever.

“And what is the excuse?” Adora grinned at her and Catra blushed deeply, looking down at her guitar. Silence stretched between

them but Adora would give Catra all the time in the world if it was necessary. After a deep breath, she spoke.

"I'm gonna sing you a song, then I'm gonna propose something to you, and you can no." Catra rushed out with a dismissive wave and Adora's eyes widened as she blushed. Before she could get a word in, Catra strummed her guitar and started playing. Okay, so she was not wasting time.

It only took seconds for Adora to blush deeper when she realized it was a love song and grinned widely when she noticed Catra trying to not nervously laugh halfway through the first verse when she noticed Adora's blush and awestruck expression. Moreover, the song was a redefined promise, an update that also poured over Catra's emotions for Adora while begging her to stay. It was vulnerability displayed beautifully but it was also terrorizing for Catra, so Adora appreciated and savored the moment while it lasted. *As long as you're here with me* , *I know I'll be okay* was the last lyric Catra could manage out before she tried harmonizing and finally broke into an embarrassed laughter that had Adora laughing with her.

Catra tried to play again, but Adora took her hand and gathered the courage to speak her next words.

"But we haven't kissed yet." Adora mumbled and Catra's smile fell into a serious then determined expression. Adora's eyes flickered down to her lips then back to mismatched eyes but Catra's stayed fixated on hers.

Who leaned in first didn't matter to Adora, not when she finally felt Catra's soft lips against hers and she drowned at the moment, totally ignoring how sloppy their kiss turned out to be. It was their first and the only guide they had were soap operas. The equation just writes itself on that one but neither of them gave three fucks. They kissed with determination until they settled on a comfortable pace that had sparks flying between them and when they had to pull back for a gasp of breath, they were hesitant to do so. Adora had braced her hands behind Catra, which was somewhat

awkward with the guitar between them, and she leaned her forehead against hers with a soft sigh.

"I want to start my new life with you. We have enough. Let's leave tomorrow, please." Catra tilted her head slightly to look down at Adora with a plea that was unnecessary. Of course, Adora would say yes, Catra didn't have to ask her twice for her to agree and just run away with Catra once more. Especially not with her feelings being finally free and reciprocated. "I want to start my history with you." She referenced the song and Adora grinned.

"Sap." Catra smacked her shoulder playfully and Adora chuckled before giving Catra a serious look. "Let's do it." Catra grinned and looked at Adora with fondness.

"I love you, Adora." Adora's breath hitched.

"I love you too."

****

"Have you considered that maybe we should buy the tickets?"

"Oh come on. We could use that money for something else."

"Catra…"

"Adora, relax. We've done this countless times." Catra waved her off and Adora bit her lip as they both searched around for their victim.

The train station was *packed* . Like, hella full today and truthfully they didn't know why. Maybe it was because the holidays were officially over and people were starting to return home or maybe it was just a busy day, they didn't know. The people who couldn't afford planes nowadays, considering how rare they were because of pollution in the sky, traveled through trains and it always proved to be a large sector of the population. Adora let out a deep sigh and took Catra's hand, smiling when the other girl gave it a squeeze. Stolen tickets or not, Adora just wanted right now to

collapse and fall asleep cuddled up to Catra on the train seats. They had decided this morning to leave some of their belongings, including Catra's guitar, with Seahawk so he could send them over once they contacted him from Republic City to avoid getting charged for the luggage and the extra weight in case something went wrong. That last thought also made them form a small plan in case they got separated for some reason. Meet up at Angella's diner and pick up where they left off, Catra even throwing in the idea of staying in the city.

"There." Catra pointed to a man walking with two passes in his hand towards his partner on the opposite side of the station. He shoved them into his pocket and Catra grinned. "Same old?"

"Same old." Adora rolled her eyes and approached the man, looking down at an invisible watch on her wrist. She crashed hard into him with a loud gasp and the man turned to glare at her as was expected. Adora saw Catra sneaking in from behind with her peripheral but she focused on the man.

"I am so sorry, sir." She apologized with a sheepish grin and started trying to fix the coat which was also meant to distract from Catra's patting. It always worked but this time…

"Stop touching me!" The man slapped Adora's hands away and stepped back just as Catra started taking the passes and bumped harshly into her. He turned around and saw her, then tickets, then back at Catra's now fearful face, then patted his pockets.

Shit .

"Is there a problem here, sir?" One of the guards approached them and the man pointed at Catra. Catra looked at Adora wide-eyed and Adora understood the message clearly. *Run.*

They both took off in a sprint before the man could explain the situation, the train security hot on their trail. Adora thought of running out of the station but Catra sprinted towards the security gates towards the trains.

They were running side by side, and they both pushed people out of the way to get to the security gates. Adora managed to get through the front of the line first and quickly made her way through the gate once Catra scanned behind her before the guards noticed, feeling relief when she saw Catra getting through as well- Was she fucking smiling?! Un-fucking-believable. That didn't matter. Adora could only focus on getting them out of there and into the train before they got caught. Adrenaline pumped through her whole being as she searched frantically. The shouts from the guards were getting closer, and Adora could only trust Catra was behind her as she started frantically pushing through the multitude. She could've sworn she was heading towards the direction where the train for Oregon was but her mind was so clouded, so frantic, so *afraid* that suddenly she wasn't sure. Adora did register the doors to the train about to close and she gritted her teeth, pushing a lady out of the way and throwing in one final sprint.

Adora made it. The sigh of relief she let out was loud but cut short when she heard the faint whooshing sound of the door closing and something hitting against it. Her stomach tied up in knots and she turned around to see her current worst fear come true. Catra, her lover, her friend, her lifeline, behind the glass door, looking terrified and gripping her nose.

"No…" Adora whispered and quickly made her way towards the door. Her heart was hammering against her chest, she was shaking like never before, and almost choking on her own breath. When they locked eyes, she lost it.

"Catra!"

***

Los Angeles, 2144 (3 years later)

Adora's boots hit the pavement loudly as she skillfully navigated the city she called home, bathing in the warm sun she certainly had missed as opposed to the cold weather in Boston. It took her a lot to settle in with Mara and the rest of the Mystacor crew and she was eternally grateful for the second opportunity in life after she almost lost her first. However, as happy as Adora was with the organization and working at Mystacor, a certain someone would never leave her mind. The last thing Catra and Adora did before getting separated was share a long meaningful kiss and a love confession that played in her dreams constantly and haunted Adora whenever the endorphins wore off after her shower encounters back in prison. Part of her felt like she was cheating, feeling like a hypocrite whenever she'd get jealous at the thought of someone touching Catra the same way but another part of her couldn't help it. She longed for the connection she had to Catra both physically and mentally but, no matter how much Adora imagined the hands and mouths on her body were Catra's, it was never enough.

Nothing was enough .

The phrase brought to Adora a vile taste in her mouth. She didn't even want to begin to think about that.

Of course, thinking that Catra would be in their emergency meetup spot after three years of radio silence from Adora was far-fetched but she wouldn't rest until she found *something* out. Adora couldn't help but feel hopeful once her "new identity" was officialized and Mara cleared her to travel, saying that she wouldn't have any trouble as long as she behaved. Yes, Adora rolled her eyes at that one but it didn't matter. She was free and Adora knew exactly where she wanted to go. If she remembered correctly, Angella's diner was supposed to be down the street she was walking on but her mind was slightly fuzzy from all the cyber job that was done to her without regulations. That fucking sucked but there was nothing to do about that, so Adora settled on keeping her eyes glued to the signs of the passing establishments. Finally, Adora got to her destination, a surge of emotions so

strong that she didn't notice the person that suddenly bumped into her.

"Oh, sorry." Adora apologized on instinct but didn't care when she didn't hear a word back. She was *here* .

The bell to the establishment jiggled upon her entrance and Adora looked around the diner with her heart caught up in her throat. She could've sworn she was about to pass out then and there but a familiar figure caught her eye.

"Angella." Adora simply said walking over to the table with a grin. Angella was looking down at the plates in deep thought but, once she looked up and spotted Adora, her jaw fell to the floor, and quickly stood up.

"Adora!" They shared a long warm hug that Adora could happily categorize as motherly and Angella pulled back with a nervous grin. "It is so nice to see you! Please. Sit." Adora furrowed her eyebrows slightly at the tone but slowly sat down, keeping her hands on her lap and staring at a fidgety Angella. What was wrong? "What brings you around here? You look…" Angella seemed to struggle for the right word usage.

"Different?" Yeah, that was safe to say. Apart from her now muscular build, Adora had only one photo of herself before she got thrown into prison. The other day she stood in front of her mirror half-dressed, looking between the mugshot and herself with a deep frown. Adora had *aged* and looked rough for her age and it made her beyond insecure.

To her surprise, Angella smiled.

"Grown. You're not a little kid anymore and I'm proud to see you've grown and didn't give up." Her smile faltered slightly and Adora knew what she was talking about. Angella was praising her for being here looking for Catra, which meant that Catra *was* here at some point waiting. Suddenly the image of Catra waiting in one

of these booths solidified in Adora's mind, bringing tears to her eyes.

"How is she?" Adora whispered and looked up at Angella, who was looking down at her hands on the table with an unreadable expression. Angella wouldn't still look her in the eyes.

"I don't know. I have not heard from her."

Adora swallowed.

"How long did she wait?"

Silence.

Angella finally locked eyes with her.

"Three weeks."

Adora took a deep shaky breath and fisted her hands on her lap. Three weeks. The image now was clear. Three weeks of Catra sitting around doing Lord knows what while waiting for Adora who was crying and yelling desperately at guards to let her go so she could be *here.* Adora tried to breathe deeply to stabilize herself.

"Where did she go?"

"She would not tell me." Adora furrowed her eyebrows in frustration and she knew she was staring Angella down but the woman simply reached over and offered her hand. Adora reached over and squeezed it softly, looking for some grounding. "She ought to be safe. She is a survivalist. I learned that in the small time we shared together." That at least was true and it eased Adora's mind slightly if it wasn't for the most obvious thought. Catra learned how to live without her. That sent a pang to her chest.

"I should go." Adora stood up abruptly but Angella stood with her, still holding her hand.

“You’re leaving so soon? Perhaps you’d like to have a walk around the city? Go see your friend Seahawk then come back to have some lunch?” Adora’s lip quivered at the invitation but she slowly shook her head. Adora was numb, heartbroken, she didn’t know what to do. She just wanted to go home, though she didn’t have one anymore so Mystacor would have to do. Catra was her home and Adora had *lost* her.

“How about a coffee to catch up before I go?” Angella brightened up at Adora’s proposition and started cleaning out the table. Adora helped.

Adora had only one thing in her mind that would stay with her for the following years, though.

She would search for Catra and never stop even if it was the end of the world.

Chapter End Notes

> And this one is done :D I was supposed to upload this chapter with Catra's memory log on White Lies but alas :(I couldn't.
>
> If you read both, though, (SPOILER) the answer is yeah Catra and Adora bumped in L.A. and didn't notice. Also, no, Angella didn't tell Catra that Adora had been in L.A., they left that same day and she didn't have the chance. Catra had left Brightmoon when Angella told Glimmer.
>
> Also, if you want to read more of my work while I finish White Lies (which is taking so damn long, I'm sorry) I have a new Catradora AU on my profile and a Korrasami one soon :D
>
> Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!